

Italian Family Aims to Prove Its Painting Is a Picasso

A family in Italy hopes to prove that a painting found long ago on the island of Capri is the work of Spanish artist Pablo Picasso.

The family has been gathering scientific evidence to support the claim. It wants officials of the Picasso estate to confirm Picasso as the painting's creator.

A man found the painting in a load of waste he took possession of as a junk dealer more than 60 years ago. He hung the picture in his home for a long time. Later, it hung in a restaurant in Pompei, Italy.

Then the man's son, Andrea Lo Russo, began to investigate the painting that, he said, his mother described as "ugly."

He said he first came to think the painting was important after seeing a picture of a Picasso painting in a schoolbook. Later, as a young adult, Lo Russo and his brother took the painting to Paris. They showed it to experts at the Picasso Museum there.

"They looked, and they said, 'it is not possible,'" Lo Russo remembered. The brothers refused the museum's offer to keep the painting for further study, he said.

Lo Russo said that his research into the painting's origin sometimes connected him with dishonest people. He said some people tricked him for money. One situation led officials to investigate him as a possible trafficker of false artwork.

That investigation ended after he produced paperwork confirming his effort to identify the family's painting.

After more than 20 years of trying, Lo Russo believes that recent tests carried out by the Swiss-based Arcadia Foundation prove that his painting is from Picasso.

Luca Marcante is a trained chemist who started the Arcadia Foundation in 2000 to investigate artwork. Marcante said laboratory tests show the paints used were like those Picasso used in one period of his career.

A painting is seen at a restoration laboratory in Milan, Italy, Thursday, Oct. 3, 2024. (AP Photo/Antonio Calanni)

Most recently, a handwriting expert confirmed that the name written in the upper left corner of the painting is Picasso's handwriting, Marcante said.

For the art world, however, only one group can authenticate the painting as Picasso's work: the Picasso Administration in Paris. But, it has not answered a series of requests over the years.

Marcante said that he is preparing to share the most recent findings with them. He explains it this way: "You need to understand, they get dozens of inquiries every day from private people believing they have found a Picasso."

The Picasso Administration chose not to speak to the Associated Press about the painting.

Tete du femme

Marcante said the painting is similar to Tete du femme, a 1949 painting that is believed to be a Picasso. It is part of a digital collection overseen by Sam Houston State University in Texas.

Adding to the mystery, Marcante said there is photographic evidence that Picasso visited the ruins of Pompeii in 1917. Marcante also said it is likely the artist visited Capri in the 1940s.

Luca Marcante, left, founder of the Arcadia Foundation, and Mauro Maurizio pose next to a painting in Milan, Italy, Thursday, Oct. 3, 2024 (AP Photo/Antonio Calanni)

But expert Enrique Mallen doubts the painting is really Picasso's work. He said, "From what I know of studying Picasso for 30 years, he would never do an identical copy of his own work."

The only record of Tete du femme is documentation from a 1967 book, which said the painting was in a private collection in Turin, Italy. Mallen said there is no other evidence of the painting.

Marcante called Tete du femme "a ghost painting, because no one has ever seen it." He added, "The only real one is ours, that we have examined in a scientific manner..."

Lo Russo said that his family has not decided what to do with the painting if it is confirmed as a Picasso. Many people are asking about it now since news about the painting spread in recent weeks.

"We are confused ourselves," he said.

I'm Mario Ritter, Jr.

Colleen Barry reported this story for the Associated Press. Mario Ritter, Jr. adapted it for VOA Learning English.

Vocabulary

estate - n. ทรัพย์สินที่เจ้าของทิ้งไว้หลังจากเสียชีวิต และถูกบริหารจัดการโดยผู้เจ้าของแต่งตั้งให้ดำเนินการต่อไป

ugly - adj. น่าเกลียด; ซึ่งไม่น่าดู

origin - n. แหล่งกำเนิด; ต้นกำเนิด

authenticate - v. รับรองว่าเป็นของจริง; พิสูจน์ว่าเป็นของแท้

confused - adj. สับสน; งุนงง

Reading Comprehension Quiz

1. What is the primary objective of the Italian family regarding the painting mentioned in the article?

- A) To sell the painting for a high price to a private collector.
- B) To confirm that the painting is an authentic work by Pablo Picasso.
- C) To donate the painting to the Picasso Museum in Paris.
- D) To discover the identity of the person who found the painting.

2. What type of evidence has the family been collecting to support their claim about the painting?

- A) Historical documents from art auctions.
- B) Personal testimonies from art critics.
- C) Scientific evidence and expert opinions.
- D) Financial records of previous sales.

3. How did the painting first come into the possession of the man who hung it in his home?

- A) He purchased it from a gallery.
- B) He inherited it from a relative.
- C) He found it in a load of waste as a junk dealer.
- D) It was given to him by a friend.

4. What was Andrea Lo Russo's mother's initial description of the painting?

- A) Beautiful
- B) Valuable
- C) Ugly
- D) Mysterious

5. What prompted Andrea Lo Russo to start believing the painting might be important?

- A) He found a signature on the painting.
- B) He saw a picture of a Picasso painting in a schoolbook.
- C) An art expert visited his home.
- D) His brother encouraged him to investigate.

6. How did the experts at the Picasso Museum in Paris react when Lo Russo first presented the painting to them?

- A) They confirmed it was a genuine Picasso.
- B) They immediately offered to acquire it for the museum.
- C) They expressed skepticism, stating, 'it is not possible.'
- D) They suggested it was a copy of another artist's work.

7. What unfortunate incident did Andrea Lo Russo face during his research into the painting's origin?

- A) He accidentally damaged the painting.
- B) He was tricked for money and investigated for potentially trafficking false artwork.
- C) He lost contact with the Picasso Administration.
- D) He was unable to find any relevant historical records.

8. How was Lo Russo able to resolve the investigation against him for possible trafficking of false artwork?

- A) He paid a large fine to the authorities.
- B) He hired a renowned lawyer to defend him.
- C) He produced paperwork confirming his efforts to identify the painting.
- D) He proved the painting was authentic at that time.

9. According to Luca Marcante of the Arcadia Foundation, what did recent laboratory tests on the painting's materials indicate?

- A) The canvas used was modern, not from Picasso's era.
- B) The paints used were similar to those Picasso employed during a specific period of his career.
- C) The painting contained no pigments commonly found in Picasso's works.
- D) The materials suggested the painting was a 20th-century forgery.

10. What was the most recent finding presented by Luca Marcante to support the painting's authenticity?

- A) A new photograph of Picasso with the painting.
- B) A handwriting expert confirmed the name on the painting was Picasso's handwriting.
- C) The discovery of Picasso's personal stamp on the back of the canvas.
- D) An interview with a person who saw Picasso paint it.

11. Why does Luca Marcante suggest the Picasso Administration might not have responded to their requests?

- A) The administration is only interested in officially recognized artworks.
- B) They have a policy of not communicating with private individuals.
- C) They receive dozens of similar inquiries every day from people believing they've found a Picasso.
- D) They are currently understaffed and cannot process all requests.

12. To what existing artwork does Marcante compare the family's painting due to its similarity?

- A) Les Demoiselles d'Avignon
- B) Guernica
- C) Tete du femme
- D) The Weeping Woman

13. What supporting evidence does Marcante provide that Picasso might have been in the region where the painting was found?

- A) Written invitations from local patrons to Picasso.
- B) Photographic evidence of Picasso visiting Pompeii in 1917 and likely Capri in the 1940s.
- C) Records of Picasso purchasing art supplies in Naples.
- D) Testimonies from locals who claimed to have met Picasso there.

14. Why does expert Enrique Mallen express doubt about the painting's authenticity?

- A) He believes the artistic style does not match Picasso's known periods.
- B) He states Picasso would never create an identical copy of his own work.
- C) He questions the scientific methods used by the Arcadia Foundation.
- D) He believes the materials used are not consistent with Picasso's art.

15. How does Luca Marcante distinguish the family's painting from 'Tete du femme'?

- A) He says 'Tete du femme' is a clear forgery, while theirs is genuine.
- B) He calls 'Tete du femme' a 'ghost painting' that no one has seen, implying their painting is the only real one scientifically examined.
- C) He believes 'Tete du femme' is an earlier sketch for the family's finished painting.
- D) He suggests 'Tete du femme' is a more famous and valuable artwork.